

Recent Publications

Edited by John Hinks

LEICESTERSHIRE AND RUTLAND: GENERAL

BROMLEY: A MIDLANDS FAMILY HISTORY AND THE SEARCH FOR THE LEICESTERSHIRE ORIGINS

Peter Bromley

Leicester, Troubador, 2007, xviii, 215pp, ISBN 1905237952

Family history is often a fairly solitary pursuit, with information gleaned from extensive research shared only with other family members, often in a rather home-made form (although recent software makes it possible to improve presentation very easily). This attractive volume shows what can be achieved when research into one family is offered more widely through traditional printed publication. It is clearly written and, while I would normally be critical of the extensive use of long quotations from source documents, they are probably justified in this kind of publication. The large-format paperback is well designed and illustrated with photographs, charts and coats of arms. The volume will undoubtedly be of interest to members of the Bromley family and those connected with them. It is also of interest to family historians as a demonstration of what can be achieved if 'proper' publication is required, but the history of one family, however well written and nicely presented, is unlikely to engage the interest of a much wider audience.

John Hinks

GREATER LOVE: MEMORIES OF SOLDIER BOYS FROM THE GREAT WAR OF 1914-18

Michael Kendrick

[...], the author, 2007, 296pp

Michael Kendrick's third book on the Great War consists primarily of biographies of local soldiers and sailors, the majority from north-west Leicestershire, and many with service in the Leicestershire Regiment. These are based on the memories of family members, along with letters, postcards, Christmas cards and other memorabilia, war diaries and military records. There are also sections on particular events – such as the Zeppelin raid on Loughborough – and poems by the author. It is difficult to do justice here to the depth of information in the book, and the enormous amount of research that has clearly gone into each entry. It will be a real treasure trove for family history researchers fortunate enough to find one of their relatives included here, but each biography is considered in the wider

context of World War I, making the book of interest to the general reader. There is no index, but the list of contents identifies each individual, making it simple for a reader to search for a particular person, and over 500 photographs are included. The author indicates that this will be his last book on World War I. He is currently working on a volume entitled *Sons and Daughters*, based on the Second World War.

Cynthia Brown

THE GREEN BICYCLE MURDER AND NEW EVIDENCE

Alison M. Keay

Loughborough, Reprint, [2007], v, 62pp

This is a typical product of the *Reprint* stable; a simply reproduced and bound A4 pamphlet at a reasonable price (£6 including postage). It is also something of a curiosity. How near Alison Keay comes to achieving her goal it is hard to assess, as there is neither introduction nor conclusion to suggest what her intention may have been in gathering together this digest of writings on the Green Bicycle case. Both would have added considerably to the value of the pamphlet. One of the curious features of the case (as this compendium amply demonstrates) is the quantity of nonsense it has generated in the (almost) eighty years since Bella Wright's murdered body was found on the Gartree Road. It is a mystery nearly as great as the murder, how such quantities of ink can be expended on the antics of blood-gorged ravens (or rooks) and on the markings and characteristics of revolver bullets. I missed Alison Keay's own views on these forensic side tracks; were they reproduced for completeness despite their apparent eccentricity? Or does she feel dead birds really do hold the key to the case?

There is much of interest here but precious little new evidence. Some of what is reprinted is plainly wrong too – assertions in the opening 'newspaper article about the case', that Bella Wright's grave is lost and that Ronald Light was of 'impeccable character' for example, are left uncorrected. There is no mention of Light's apparent secret confession, recorded by Superintendent Bowley at the end of his trial, nor of the character-damning evidence gathered by Wendy East for her study of the case. As a summary of the case, this is a useful piece of work. It might have benefited from a few 'health warnings' from the compiler – but if it represents a

half-way house, as Alison Keay works towards her definitive study of the murder and its historiography, I should value it all the more.

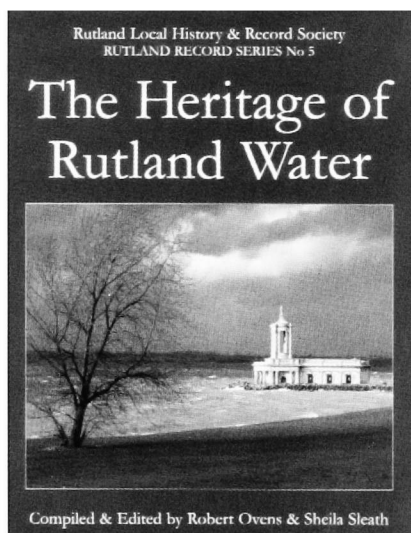
Robin Jenkins

THE HERITAGE OF RUTLAND WATER

R. Ovens & S. Sleath (eds)

Oakham, Rutland Local History Society, 2nd edn. 2008, 680pp, ISBN 9780907464419

All who have contributed to this book are to be congratulated, especially the joint editors Robert Ovens and Sheila Sleath, and the Rutland Local History and Record Society for initiating and completing the project. Within its 680 pages there are thirty contributions covering soils, geology, agriculture, archaeology, ornithology, fauna and flora, fishing, sailing and more. They are all extensively illustrated with a mixture of colour and black and white pictures and diagrams. There are two indexes, one general and the other covering surnames, organizations and corporate bodies, and a bibliography. Good design and layout clearly stand out in this production which is a splendid publication.



Alan McWhirr

INN-VESTIGATED: THE ORIGINS OF PUBLIC HOUSE NAMES

C R Townsend

Syston, the author, 2007, 58pp

£5.75 (including P&P) from 0116 260 8663 or crtownsend@talktalk.net

One could be forgiven, in these days of rapidly changing pub names, for thinking that no-one (especially the big breweries) is interested in the names of our local hostleries. It is sad when pubs, often local landmarks of considerable age, are suddenly given trendy new names which sever them from their history. The traditional names of many pubs are in fact of considerable interest and this book tells the story of a wide selection of the pub names of Leicestershire (and some from further afield) in an informative and sometimes jocular manner, with a number of inn-signs illustrated. This

may not be serious, academic local history but it is readable and entertaining, and none the worse for that.

John Hinks

PASSING MUSTER: THE MILITIA IN LEICESTERSHIRE AND RUTLAND ON THE 250TH ANNIVERSARY OF THE MILITIA ACT OF 1757

Robin Jenkins

Leicester, Record Office, 2007, 12pp

This pamphlet was printed by the Record Office to accompany a 2007 exhibition about the militia. Part-time soldiers have for a long time been an important ingredient of the British Army. This pamphlet succinctly and elegantly sets out a brief history of volunteer infantry prior to, and after, the Militia Act of 1757. Militia were at that time seen as a support for the army, rather than a substitute for them. The end of the militia came in 1908 with the formation of the Territorial Army and then the subsequent raising of the Home Guard in 1940. A discussion of how to find your ancestor in the surviving Militia Lists is given plus references to other records held by the Record Office and the Royal Leicestershire Regiment. An appendix discusses discipline and indiscipline, exclusions and substitutions, with some fascinating short accounts from the archives and information about guarding Dutch prisoners of war at Norman Cross in 1796-8. This pamphlet is available from the Record Office and can also be downloaded as a Word document from the County Council Website www.leics.gov.uk - (Record Office, Leaflets and Handlists). Recommended as a very interesting read.

Kathy Harman

RUTLAND RECORD No. 27 (for 2007)

Journal of the Rutland Local History and Record Society
ISSN 0260-3322

The high quality of this annual journal is maintained with number 27. It is a credit to the Society and its editor. There are three main articles in this edition: 'Rutland passes muster: aspects of the Militia' by Robin Jenkins, 'Railways in Rutland' by John Wales and 'The Last Hunters and Gatherers of the Uppingham Plateau' by Elaine Jones. There is also the usual round-up of history and archaeology in the county edited by Tim Clough. All are authoritative and well-written accounts and are accompanied by clear and informative illustrations. Copies can be purchased by non-members of the Society.

Alan McWhirr

TO THE LAST ROUND: THE LEICESTERSHIRE AND RUTLAND HOME GUARD 1940-1945

Austin J Ruddy

Derby, Breedon, 2007, ISBN 9781859835593

If you are interested in the local history of the Second World War this book should definitely be either on your bookshelf or borrowed from your local library. When I first started to read it I thought that perhaps I would read the first half, being the chronological historical account of the Home Guard in the two counties, and then skip through the remaining chapters on military defences, people, training, uniforms, weapons. To my surprise, however, despite the small typeface which I found hard at first, this book held my attention right to the 'Finis' cartoon on the last page. This is a totally fascinating account of what the Home Guard was really about without completely removing the televised impression from *Dad's Army*. In Leicestershire and Rutland 50,000 men and some women were involved in the Home Guard, organised into fourteen Battalions and Anti-Aircraft Units. Whilst this structure and locations are easily known the author's detailed research has uncovered the existence of more shadowy 'Shock' sections, primed to be saboteurs should invasion take place.

It is fortunate that an invasion did not take place for many of the Home Guard would have been sacrificed to the cause of slowing up the enemy before regular troops arrived. It is also true that had invasion taken place early in the war then even this ability would not have been good. It was not until later, when the invasion threat had receded, that the Home Guard became a more efficient unit. Nowadays we complain about health and safety regulations – but there were eighteen fatalities whilst on duty (though some were from natural causes). Take for example the young man crossing the River Soar at Wanlip in a canoe with his mate during a training exercise, and, being obscured from view, was blown in two when a depth charge was set off. I was also fascinated to learn what still remains around the two counties from this time and to see pictures of places that I pass every day where roadblocks used to be.

Kathy Harman

THE WARS OF THE ROSES: A FIELD GUIDE AND COMPANION

Peter Bramley

Stroud, Sutton, 2007, xiv, 274pp, ISBN 9780750941013

There was a time when my preparation for a family holiday simply meant the selection of the appropriate OS maps, 'Pevsner' and *Little Guide* (which, though hardly current, did at least indulge my taste for ecclesiology). Then along

came Simon Jenkins and his hefty *Thousand Best Churches*. Now, with the appearance of this attractive and useful tome, I shall seriously have to consider either a larger car or leaving one of the children at home. This is a volume to be enjoyed by a far wider readership than its title might suggest. It is beautifully illustrated, with colour plates that doubtless added much to the £25 price-tag, and engagingly written. It is certainly to be carried about by those who seek out historic England and Wales but it is also an agreeable enough read to be enjoyed by those whose travels are cerebral rather than physical. Indeed, as the better weather comes, I foresee many a foray into the past at Peter Bramley's prompting and with him as a genial courier. The veracity of this book as a field guide is attested by the profusion of excellent photographs, presumably taken by the author, and by the practical directions to find the places mentioned (or the keys to them). I appreciate too the hints about suitable picnic spots; the provisioning of those in the field being no less important (for morale as much as sustenance) in 2008 as it was in 1458!

Inevitably, there will be quibbles with the personal views of the author. One might reasonably ask why Ashby de la Zouch is omitted (save as a passing reference under Kirby Muxloe). What about the plaque at Sevenoaks recording the defeat of Sir Humphrey Stafford at Solefield? Would it be worth mentioning that while the Yorkist monuments at Fotheringhay are Elizabethan reconstructions, the fifteenth century originals still peep from beneath them – and that surely the Royalist entrenchments at Northampton would have extended beyond the Nene bridge? These though are quibbles and it is such arguments that engage the reader and make this so worthwhile a book. Whether you like to sample your history from an armchair or scramble up and down the 'red gutters' and 'bloody meadows' that bespatter the landscape about us, I have no hesitation in commending this 'field guide and companion' to you. I would write more but I find I (and my camera) have an appointment with Sir Humphrey Stafford in St John's, Bromsgrove!

Robin Jenkins

Other recent publications

DID BONNIE PRINCE CHARLIE VISIT LEICESTERSHIRE?

John Harrison

Loughborough, Reprint, [2007], 56pp

DRIVING SPACES: A CULTURAL-HISTORICAL GEOGRAPHY OF ENGLAND'S M1 MOTORWAY

Peter Merriman

Oxford, Blackwell, 2007, xiv, 305pp, ISBN 9781405130721

DUNCAN'S LEICESTERSHIRE DITTIES

Duncan Lucas

Wigston Magna, D. Lucas, [2007], 33pp

CITY OF LEICESTER

**BELGRAVE MEMORIES: TALES OF BELGRAVE
TRANSCRIPTS: 1945 TO 2005: SIXTY YEARS OF
HERITAGE**

Bill Law & Tim Haq (eds)

Leicester, Contact Cultures, 2007, 386pp, 9780955585319

BELGRAVE MEMORIES 1945 TO 2005

Bill Law & Tim Haq (eds)

Leicester, Contact Cultures, 116pp, ISBN 9780955585333

Both these publications originate from an oral history project, funded by the Heritage Lottery Fund, which interviewed more than eighty people connected with the Belgrave area of Leicester between 1945 and 2005. The interviews are transcribed in full in *Belgrave Memories: Tales of Belgrave Transcripts*, while the *Belgrave Memories* book brings together extracts from them alongside photographs and documentary sources, to chart the history of the area over the past sixty years. As the book demonstrates, this has been a period of great change for Belgrave. At the end of World War II it was a predominantly white working class area, quiet enough to play Tin Lurkey and other games in the street, with many houses where shared outside toilets were still common. One resident recalls that, even in 1945: 'My relations had horses and carts. On Saturday afternoons, me and my cousin used to take the horse and cart down to Sanvey Gate, we used to bed the horses down in the stables every Saturday without fail'.

Even then, the population of Belgrave was more diverse than might be thought, with people from Poland, Germany and Belgium making their home there; by the end of the century, migration from the Indian sub-continent, East Africa and other parts of the world had transformed Belgrave into a multi-ethnic neighbourhood with a majority Gujarati Hindu community. Alongside the memories of existing residents, both the transcripts and *Belgrave Memories* book tell the stories of those who moved there during this sixty-year period, of their reasons for migrating, their early experiences of settling in Leicester, the work they did and the businesses they established, and their religious and cultural life. They also give a sense of the processes of migration within the city itself by which different religious or ethnic communities became concentrated in particular areas; and of the ways in which Belgrave continues to change. As one resident observes. 'we're seeing a lot more different cultures coming

in. There are Somalis and Turkish, which is great. It's adding a lot more value to the area... Even in the Asian shops you're seeing more of the other communities coming in. They're curious to see what the dresses, the fashion, the food as well, is like'.

Some white interviewees expressed concern that 'our traditions are being lost because of political correctness... I think people are so afraid to offend one section or another of the community... you are almost afraid to be proud of your country or celebrate your country'. Interviewees from migrant communities also talked about the 'generation gap' that many feel has opened between them and their children, born and brought up in a western society, and issues around changes in Asian culture in relation to the care of ageing parents. Overall, however, the view of Belgrave presented by the interviewees is a very positive one, a celebration in many ways of the 'tolerance and willingness to adapt' of its population. For the general reader, the *Belgrave Memories* book is recommended for a very readable, well illustrated and illuminating overview of change in this area of Leicester since 1945, while the full transcripts are an invaluable resource for further study. It is good to see an oral history project that succeeds in giving a voice to such a wide cross-section of people.

Cynthia Brown

**FRANCIS 'TANKY' SMITH (LEICESTER'S FIRST
PRIVATE DETECTIVE)**

C R Townsend

Syston, the author, 2007, 18pp

£1.85 (including P&P) from 0116 260 8663 or
crtownsend@talktalk.net

Everyone knows a little about 'Tanky' Smith. Everyone knows that he was Leicester's Sherlock Holmes; that he affected dozens of cunning disguises (though surely not as bizarre as some of those Townsend suggests) and that he pursued the missing Winstanley heir as far as his watery grave in Coblenz. We have all wandered past 'top hat terrace' and marvelled at the brown-hatted busts. I suspect also that I am not alone in wanting to know more. Now, C R Townsend's attractive little pamphlet adds a few more facts to the story. We know that Francis Smith was baptised in 1814 and married in 1836 (though, frustratingly, we are not told Smith's occupation). From apparently very lowly origins, he joined the new Leicester Borough police in 1840, rising through the ranks to become inspector in 1853. By 1862, Smith was sufficiently renowned to be hired by the Winstanleys, and soon after to retire into prosperous private work.

This little study answers some questions but leaves the field open for a detailed study. The author intends no more (hinting that he has the details of early cases – ‘too long winded to insert’) but if he whets the appetite of another researcher, who can produce the definitive ‘Tanky’, I should be grateful indeed. Why did Smith’s police career end in such unpleasantness? Where did he get his money? The bones of the story are here – now we need the flesh. Francis Smith must have been a remarkable man and if a modern, literary detective follows up half the leads this author suggests, we should have a yarn well worth the telling.

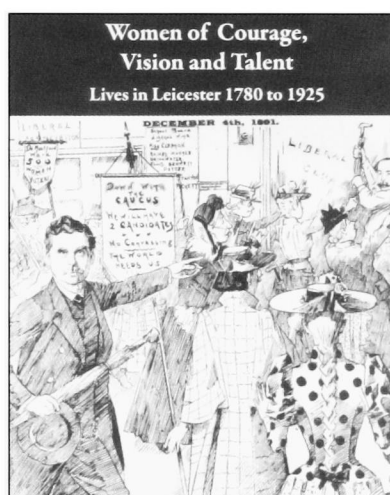
Robin Jenkins

**WOMEN OF COURAGE, VISION AND TALENT:
LIVES IN LEICESTER 1780 TO 1925**

Shirley Aucott

Leicester, the author, 2008, ix, 266pp, ISBN 9780954818920

Shirley Aucott has painstakingly researched the lives of around 102 women who had connections with Leicester, and in this book she reproduces accounts of these women following an introductory chapter. She also produces a very useful ‘Timeline of important national acts and events that affected women’s lives’. After the detailed biographical accounts there are eleven appendices which are a very useful resource, followed by an extensive bibliography and an index. This book will stimulate a great deal of interest in women who lived and worked in Leicester and encourage others interested in Leicester’s past to provide the author with much additional material when she comes to update the work!



Alan McWhirr

Other recent publications

**FLAVOURS OF LEICESTER: YOUNG LEICESTER
ASIANS LOOK AT THEIR HERITAGE**

Leicester, Contact Cultures, 2007, 24pp, ISBN 9780955585302

**GEOLOGY OF GRAVESTONES IN WELFORD ROAD
CEMETERY, LEICESTER**

Helen Boynton

The author, 2007, 24pp

**TELL ME SOMETHING I DON'T KNOW ABOUT
LEICESTER: A HISTORY OF LEICESTER
VOLUME 2**

Derek Hollingworth

Loughborough, Reprint, [2007], iv, 113pp

TOWNS, VILLAGES AND HOUSES

**ASHBY-DE-LA-ZOUCH CASTLE: HISTORIC AND
DESCRIPTIVE**

Thomas H. Fosbrooke

Loughborough, Reprint, [1914, reprinted 2007], 44pp

This facsimile ring-bound booklet provides a substantive account of Ashby Castle’s history, particularly during the Civil War, and a detailed explanation of its architecture supported by measured drawings produced by the author. Thomas H. Fosbrooke, Fellow of the Society of Antiquaries, practised as an architect in Leicester and was keenly committed to the preservation of the county’s built environment and its archaeological heritage. Despite its age, the book continues to offer an authoritative source on the castle, not only for its well known connections with Mary Queen of Scots, James I and Charles I (who stayed there for one night after defeat at Naseby), but also for the history of the Zouch family and later the Hastings family who became the Earls of Huntingdon. The publication in 1819 of Walter Scott’s *Ivanhoe*, which used the castle’s setting for the famous tournament, not only aroused ‘considerable interest in the town and the castle’, but also ensured that steps were taken towards the castle’s preservation under the guidance of Francis, the first Marquis of Hastings.

The detailed account of the various castle buildings in the second part of the book provides an informative and practical guide for current day visitors. Photographs include one showing the ‘chimney piece’ and another depicting the arms of Francis, Second Earl of Huntingdon. Copies of the author’s measured drawings of the castle buildings follow at the end of the book, including a site plan of the ruins and surrounding area with a list of the Lords of the Manor from 1066 to 1910. Thomas Fosbrooke refers to many original sources in his account, and notes the help and support he received from Lady Maud Hastings and family during the book’s compilation. He was a member of the Leicestershire Architectural and Archaeological Society to whom he initially presented his work on Ashby Castle at a meeting of the Society in 1911. The paper was subsequently reproduced in the Associated Architectural Societies’ Reports & Papers (Vol. XXXI, 1911, p181-224).

As well as providing a guide for the modern visitor, this book is a useful source for anyone interested in the history of Ashby Castle, the families who lived there and the design, construction and layout of its buildings. The architectural and archaeological detail in the drawings provides an interesting visual record of professional draughtsmanship of almost a hundred years ago. Towards the end of his life, Thomas Fosbrooke maintained scrapbooks of architectural sketches and drawings, photographs, articles and other items reflecting his wide interests in the local heritage. The scrapbooks are held in the Record Office for Leicestershire, Leicester and Rutland and at the time of writing are being indexed. They contain items relating to Fosbrooke's interest in Ashby Castle, notably an original sketch of the Brick Tower before its destruction in 1908 and a news-cutting reporting that the heir to the Ashby Castle estate, Reginald Rawden Hastings, was killed in action in 1915 after this book was written.

Christine Taggart

PEEPS INTO BILLESDON'S PAST

Billesdon Local History Group, 2007, 24pp, ISBN 9780953964512

This booklet marks the twenty-first anniversary of the formation of the Billesdon Local History Group in 1986. It consists of a selection of articles contributed by its members to the *Billesdon & District News and Views* between 1989 and 1995, based on their research into documentary sources such as parish registers, school log books and the records of the Billesdon Union Workhouse, along with the memories of local residents. Around two-thirds of the articles were written by the late George Bromley, who chaired the group for many years. They cover a wide range of topics from ancient trackways to school life and local industries, through to World War II and the Prisoner of War Camp on the Gaulby Road. Although based on Billesdon, many of the articles also offer wider historical insights – such as that on the Potter family and their work as taxidermists. While much of this was concerned with supplying stuffed foxes heads, birds, fish and badgers, the article notes that Frank Potter also stuffed cats and dogs 'but preferred the owner to see the animal before it had "set" to check its expression'. This is a very informative and readable publication, with a wealth of information and analysis packed into its twenty-four pages.

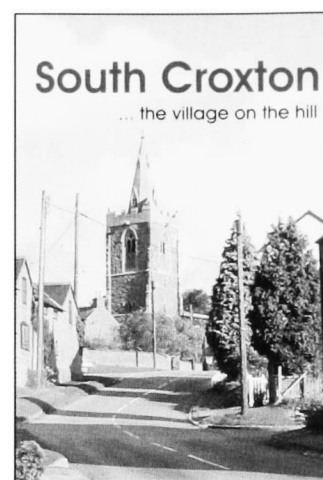
Cynthia Brown

SOUTH CROXTON – THE VILLAGE ON THE HILL

Philip Snelders

South Croxton Parish Council, 2005, xi, 202pp, ISBN 9780955024511

An appeal for old photographs of the village resulted in an unexpected response and this spurred the author to continue collecting them as well as other material and this now all forms the Village Archive. This consists of around 1,000 photographs, maps, documents, newspaper articles and video clips and they are stored on a CD which can be purchased separately from the author. This



archive has been edited into a book which will be a very useful account for future generations. There is an index. It is a valiant attempt and the exercise has been useful in collecting together material which is now widely accessible. One could be critical about certain aspects of the layout and typography, but with the constraints placed on those producing the book this is understandable.

Alan McWhirr

Other recent publications

BLUE PLAQUES IN WIGSTON MAGNA AND SOUTH WIGSTON: A CELEBRATION OF SOME NOTABLE LOCAL PEOPLE OF THE PAST

Wigston Civic Society, 2007, 36pp

BYGONE SILEBY: HISTORICAL FACTS ABOUT THE VILLAGE

R.J. Hunting

Loughborough, Reprint, [2007], x, 84pp

FEARON FOUNTAIN OF LOUGHBOROUGH

John Harrison

Loughborough, Reprint, [2007], 64pp

KIBWORTH IN 1851

Sue Harris

Kibworth Historical Society, 2007, 56pp

LOST LIVES: THE WAR DEAD OF COUNTSTHORPE, KILBY, PEATLING MAGNA, PEATLING PARVA AND SHEARSBY, 1914-1918 AND 1939-1945

Henrietta Schultka

[Countesthorpe], the author, 2007, 100pp, ISBN 9780955734304

**MEMORIAL INSCRIPTIONS AT SMEETON
WESTERBY GRAVEYARDS**

George Weston & Norman Harrison
Kibworth History Society, 2007, 28pp

MEMORIES OF THURMASTON

Thurmaston Heritage Group, 2007, 72pp

**THE OAKHAM PARISH FIELD WALKING SURVEY:
ARCHAEOLOGY IN THE PLOUGHLAND OF
RUTLAND**

Elaine Jones

Uppingham, the author, 2007, 96pp, ISBN 9781905933037

**SOME PAGES IN OAKHAM AND BARLEYTHORPE
HISTORY**

Kari J. Sillanpaa

[Finland], Viafor, 2007, 34pp, ISBN 9789525695021

**36 HIGH STREET WEST AND SHIELD'S YARD: A
MINI-HISTORY**

P.N. Lane

Uppingham Local History Group, 2007, iii, 43pp

**[THRINGSTONE] 'THRINKSUN' BORN AND BRED:
MEMORIES OF AN ENGLISH CHILDHOOD**

Joan B. Blackey

Thringstone on Line, [2007], 2 volumes

number of people and the impact their work has had on the local community. A section of photographs, mainly of groups of church members at various events over the years is included.

Jennifer Sandys

Other recent publications

**ILLUSTRATED GUIDE TO ST MARY'S PARISH
CHURCH, HINCKLEY**

B. Davis

Hinckley, the church, 2007, 56pp

KETTON CHURCH AND PARISH

Geoffrey Fox

Ketton, 2007, 156pp

**ONE MORE STEP... St Christopher's church, Saffron
Lane, Leicester, 1927-2007.**

Susan Barton

Leicester, the church, 2007, 20pp

ST MARY'S PARISH CHURCH, MELTON MOWBRAY

George Hows

Melton, Rawson, 2007, vi, 158pp, ISBN 9780954846930

RELIGION AND PLACES OF WORSHIP

METHODISM IN BIRSTALL: 160 YEARS 1847-2007

John Kilby

Birstall, the author, 2007, 152pp, ISBN 0951360770

The author writes from close association with the chapel, a connection which has continued from his father's and grandfather's days. He is also a local historian, being author of the first rate Birstall Village: a brief history 1900-1999 which could be used as a model village history. A labour of love, this book is written to commemorate a particular event: 160 years of Methodism in Birstall and for a particular audience: church members and perhaps villagers who will know or have recollections of some of the people involved. Largely based on records of trustee and other meetings it includes a great deal of detail of everyday administration which makes for somewhat tedious reading for anyone outside that audience. I would have found it helpful if a clear timeline of major events and a map of Birstall showing the locations of the various buildings had been included and the book would perhaps have benefited from editing by someone less closely involved. However what does come through is the hard and dedicated work of a relatively small

HEALTH, WELFARE AND EDUCATION

**DIAMOND DAYS REMEMBERED: 60 YEAR
DIAMOND JUBILEE CELEBRATION OF MEALS ON
WHEELS 1947-2007**

Leicestershire County Council, 2007, 109pp

The way we lived in the period just before and after the Second World War is captured in this collection of memories and anecdotes, produced to celebrate sixty years of 'Meals on Wheels' established by the Women's Voluntary Service. The idea for a book was conceived by the 'Meals on Wheels 60' Group, comprising staff of Leicestershire County Council's Social Services, their principal contracted community meals provider and partnership agencies. Around 1,200 elderly, frail and disabled people receiving 'Meals on Wheels' in the county during April 2007 were invited to complete a questionnaire designed to stimulate their memories and reveal an insight into their daily lives of sixty years ago. Their recollections and comments have been grouped in this book under broad categories ranging from daily essentials such as food, work and transport to the softer themes of fashion, entertainment and recreation.

Those who experienced the harsh winter of 1947 remember it well. Many recollect snowdrifts up to fifteen feet high covering hedgerows and paralysing transport: 'snow so deep that trains travelling from Burton-on-Trent to Leicester could not get through Coalville'. Poverty and hardship were exacerbated with many on the dole, stringent food rationing, a national shortage of coal: 'queuing at the gas works for coke', and having to make-do and mend. Favourite meals included roasts, stews, pies and sausages, but chickens were in short supply 'unless you had some in the backyard'. Spam (before the internet) was also popular. Few people could afford cars, and many recall travelling by steam trains, buses and bicycles or relied on Shanks's pony: 'had to walk to work from Castle Donington to Derby'. People listened to 'Dick Barton', 'Workers' Playtime' and 'The Archers' on the wireless and went to the cinema. Enjoyment was still to be found amongst the hardships of everyday life.

Facts, figures and photographs from the 1940s are interspersed throughout the text to reflect and amplify the local and national scene at the time. Interesting local photographs provided by Kegworth Museum include a village nurse on a bicycle, a steam train at Kegworth Station and framework knitters working in a front parlour. Copies of adverts from newspapers and magazines offer a nostalgic reminder of those everyday essentials such as syrup of figs, vanishing cream and dental powder. There is some duplication of illustrations, but this is essentially a 'scrapbook' for dipping into rather than reading from cover to cover. Readers expecting a purely Leicestershire picture need to be aware that people completing the questionnaire in 2007 did not necessarily live in the county sixty years ago, and many of the memories recorded could provide a social history of almost anywhere in Britain. The early days of 'Meals on Wheels' are briefly described in the text, but the book would have been enhanced with some background on the development of the service in Leicestershire, perhaps as an introduction.

Local historians will find some comments and information relating specifically to Leicestershire, but this book could most usefully support reminiscence work with older people and learning in schools. It will evoke powerful images for those old enough to remember and should help young people understand how much life has changed beyond the historical facts of the war and its aftermath. Reflecting on the pleasure of 'church bells ringing after being silenced during the war' is a poignant reminder of the stress and hardship of those days and how strength can be gained from appreciating the basic normalities of everyday life that we take for granted.

Christine Taggart

WORKHOUSES OF THE MIDLANDS

Peter Higginbotham

Stroud, Tempus, 2007, 128pp, ISBN 9780752444888

Started by Alan Sutton, Tempus Publishing's most successful and extensive series now runs to over 1000 titles on towns and villages and topics of interests to local historians. Each title concentrates on archive images, and this book illustrates almost every facet of the evolution of the workhouse in more than 100 reproduction and modern illustrations. 'The Midlands' takes in Derbyshire, Leicestershire and Rutland, Lincolnshire, Northamptonshire, Nottinghamshire, Oxfordshire, Staffordshire, Warwickshire and Worcestershire and is complemented by another volume by the same author on Workhouses of the North. Divided into two parts, the first part provides an introduction to the history of workhouses the second part a county by county directory of workhouses with photographs, plans and factual detail on the establishments concerned. The author provides a succinct, clear and sympathetic account of the development of the workhouse, from the 'old poor law' to the closure of workhouses in 1930. He illustrates his text with some well chosen extracts from the records, such as: 'In 1839 Selina Hill who had conducted herself in a way very unbecoming of her sex ...was ordered to have her hair cut short and not be allowed to wear a cap for three months'. Nowadays redundant workhouse buildings have become offices and luxury apartments; will their inhabitants ever consider the extent of shame and degradation that went on within those walls? Highly recommended.

Jennifer Sandys

Other recent publications

HISTORY OF LEICESTER FRENCH CIRCLE 1899-2007

Kathleen E. Bassett

Leicester, LFC, 2nd edn, 2007, 23pp

LEICESTERSHIRE AND RUTLAND HERITAGE OF MENTAL HEALTH

L. Maitland

[...], Recovery Resources Charity, 2008, ii, 59pp

LOOKING BACK: REMINISCENCES OF A BYGONE AGE

Ashby-de-la-Zouch, Ashby Court Nursing and Residential Home, [2007], 20pp

MEDICINE AND SOCIETY IN THE MIDLANDS, 1750-1950

Jonathan Reinartz (ed)

Birmingham, Midland History, 2007, 211pp, ISBN 9780955517204

WHETHER OR IF? RESEARCH INTO THE HISTORY OF HANDICAP IN THE COUNTY OF LEICESTERSHIRE c.1800-1900

Diane Lockley

[Markfield, the author, 2007], 49pp

INDUSTRY, TRADE AND TRANSPORT

THE LACEMAKERS' STORY: LOUGHBOROUGH, LUDDITES AND LONG JOURNEYS

Loughborough, Friends of Charnwood Museum, 2007, 32pp, ISBN 9780955626807

This book is exactly what it claims to be, a souvenir of an exhibition about lacemakers from the East Midlands. The exhibition was displayed at Charnwood Museum and the book has been produced by three members of the Friends of Charnwood Museum. It consists of images of the panels that formed the exhibition and they tell the story very well. In addition there are some images of the artefacts that were in display cabinets. There is also a useful list of suggested further reading. If I have a criticism of this book it is that the format, reduced images of the exhibition panels, means that some of the text is rather small. This will make it difficult to read for some people but the authors themselves describe it as a souvenir of the exhibition. On that level, reasonably priced at £4.95, it is well worth it.

Pat Grundy

LEICESTERSHIRE INDUSTRIAL HISTORY SOCIETY

Bulletin No. 18 2007

Bulletin No. 19 2007

DVD *Timken Tubes of Desford*

The LIHS has had a busy time publishing both Bulletins and a DVD. The two bulletins are of much higher standard than the usual ones produced by the Society as a result of a legacy from the late Peter Neaverson. They are A4 in size, they use a coated paper and include colour illustrations.

Bulletin No. 18 2007

ISBN 978-0-9556445-0-4 80pp

Number 18 is solely devoted to an account of 'Early Slate Quarries in North West Leicestershire' written by David Ramsey and it is good to see the results of his extensive research now in print for all to read.

Bulletin No. 19 2007

ISBN 978-0-9556445-1-1 76pp

This issue contains an obituary of Peter Neaverson and a collection of some of his work which has previously been published including work on the Ticknall Lime Industry, the Impact of a railway on a developed urban area – The Great Central Railway, Leicester and the Model Farm at Carlton Hayes

Hospital. It is good to see these articles brought together as a tribute to Peter Neaverson. I am sure he would have been delighted with the end product.

DVD *Timken Tubes of Desford*

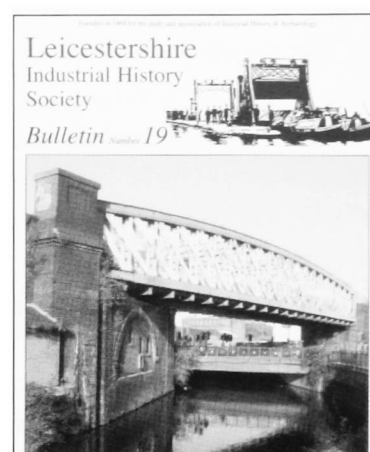
This DVD was produced in collaboration with the company following its decision to shut down the hot and cold tube mill at Desford which had been operating since the 1940s. It was the last surviving mill in the UK producing hot rolled tubes by the Assel piercing process and so this record is an important record of a significant industrial process and the LIHS is to be congratulated in having the foresight in producing this DVD. A future edition of their bulletin will have an account of the works. Copies of the DVD can be obtained from the LIHS as can other publications. They can be contacted at LIHS99@ntlworld.com

Alan McWhirr

MEMORIES OF THE LEICESTERSHIRE COALFIELDS

Newbury, Countryside Books, 2007, 128pp, ISBN 9781846740619

This is a very readable account of the Leicestershire coalfields, drawing on interviews with former miners and others employed in the industry, such as surveyors, plumbers and clerical workers. It covers a range of topics in a lively and original way. Following an overview of mining in the county, for instance, the first chapter deals with cages and winding wheels, with one interviewee recalling the experience of travelling in the cage when the winder was 'rushing because he'd got a queue to get rid of... you'd feel it rise then zonk, down you'd go. You should have heard the swearing'. Another recalled a particular pit pony at Desford which was 'notorious... if he were in a bad mood he'd bite you, give you a nip. The pit men used to give him sweets to try and keep him happy'. As the book reveals, many miners did not go straight into the pit from school, but many were eventually led there by family tradition combined with



higher wages than they could earn elsewhere. Others started work on the surface, working on the screens where the coal was sorted and graded, before going underground. Almost all had a nickname of some kind – two of the most notable being those of a father and son by the name of Moon at Bagworth, respectively known as Full-moon and Half-moon.

The social life of the pit villages is also described, along with the dangers of the work itself, and problems caused by subsidence, particularly in Bagworth where three quarters of the houses were 'wiped out. I don't think I'm exaggerating... The church went... That hurt us... And we lost the school through subsidence...'. The final chapters cover the strikes of 1972, 1974 and 1984, and the legacy of animosity left by the latter. One union official recalls that: 'In 1972, we hadn't got a clue how to strike. We'd never done it. The Transport and General Workers Union was organized to come along and teach us how to strike. Car workers knew how to strike, didn't they?'. The closure of Bagworth marked the end of coal mining in Leicestershire – but this book is a valuable addition to the industrial history of Leicestershire and of the coal mining industry itself. It includes a wealth of photographs, many of them from the archive of the Whitwick Historical Society.

Cynthia Brown

Other recent publications

THE GREAT CENTRAL RAILWAY ON OLD PICTURE POSTCARDS

Bill Taylor

Keyworth, Reflections of a Bygone Age, 2007, 36pp, ISBN 9781905408078

NATIONAL SERIES OF WATERWAY, TRAMWAY AND RAILWAY ATLASES

VOLUME 5b: LEICESTERSHIRE AND RUTLAND [less Leicester]

G.L.Crowther

Preston, Crowther, 2007, 42pp, ISBN 9781856155397

RAILWAYS AND RURAL LIFE: S.W.A. NEWTON AND THE GREAT CENTRAL RAILWAY

Gary Boyd-Hope & Andrew Sargent

Swindon, English Heritage, 2007, 215pp, ISBN 9781850749592

RAILWAYS OF LEICESTERSHIRE AND RUTLAND

David W. Webb

Hersham, Ian Allan, 2007, 96pp, ISBN 9780711032194

SYMINGTON'S: HARBOROUGH'S LOST WORKFORCE
Market Harborough Local History Group, 2007, 40pp + DVD

TRAMWAYS OF THE EAST MIDLANDS

R.J.S. Wiseman

Scarborough, Light Rail Transit Association, 2007, 88pp, ISBN 9780948106354

ULLESTHORPE WINDMILL

Daniel Burton

Ullesthorpe Preservation Trust, 2007, 16pp, ISBN 9780955585708

ENTERTAINMENT, MUSIC AND SPORT

BARWELL CRICKET CLUB BICENTENARY 1807-2007

Barwell, BCC, 2007, 48pp

BATS OF WILLOW, BALLS OF LEATHER: THE HISTORY OF BURBAGE CRICKET CLUB

Burbage Heritage Group, 2007, 67pp

CRICKET AT KIBWORTH AND SMEETON 1847-1915

Philip J. Porter

Kibworth, the author, 2007, 40pp

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